



Junction City jump

US paratroopers parachute into the drop zone, a flat and clear area west of Katum Special Forces camp, in their only major combat assault of the war. In general, Vietnam's rugged terrain made parachute assaults impractical.

The objective

As with other search-and-destroy operations, the objective of Junction City was to clear the region of North Vietnamese and Viet Cong fighters. This time, however, the operation also involved a specific target: the Central Office South Vietnam (COSVN), the mobile headquarters of the 2,000 or so staff who coordinated operations between North Vietnamese and Viet Cong fighters. Like Operation Cedar Falls, Junction City employed a "hammer-and-anvil" technique to drive enemy forces overland toward destruction.

Taking position

Under the guise of conducting routine combat patrols, US forces were placed in position for the assault. Then, on the morning of February 22, eight infantry battalions under the control of the 25th Infantry Division helicoptered into landing zones, where they met little to no resistance. At the same time, 16 Lockheed C-130 aircraft dropped 845 airborne infantry into position. Collectively, these forces then extended their lines almost to the Cambodian border, creating a horseshoe-shaped cordon designed to trap the Viet Cong so that US forces could hunt them down. In fact, for the next month, American forces had only light contact with the Viet Cong, who were content to remain hidden.

■ **249** The number of US helicopters used to drop eight infantry battalions into position on February 22.